FIRST THESSALONIANS

Conversational Version

Salutation

1:**1**Paul, Silvanus, and Timothy to the church of the Thessalonians in God the Father and the Lord Jesus Christ[Messiah]. Grace and peace. **1 Th 1:1**

Paul's Memories of the Thessalonians

2We are always grateful to God for you and include you in our prayers. We **3**remember your work of faith, *your* labor of love, and *your* enduring hope that lies in our Lord Jesus Christ in the presence of our God and Father. **4**Family of Christ loved by God, we know you're chosen **5**because our good news didn't come to you just in words, but in power, *in* the Holy Spirit, *in* complete confidence, like the kind of men you know we proved to be among you on your behalf. **6**You imitated us and the Lord, because you received the message with the joy of the Holy Spirit among lots of difficulties. **7**As a result, you became an example for the believers in Macedonia and Achaia. **8**The Lord's message rang out from you, not only in Macedonia and Achaia, but wherever your faith in God has gone. So we don't have to say anything. **9**People acknowledge how you received us, how you turned from idols to serve the true, living God; **10**how you wait for his Son from heaven—that God raised from the dead, Jesus who rescues us from the fury to come. **1 Th 1:2-10**

Paul's History with the Thessalonians

2:**1**Our coming to you proved to be productive. **2**As you know, after we'd suffered and been treated disgracefully, we gathered up the courage in our God to present his good news to you during our struggles. **3**We didn't pressure *you* with deception, impure motives, or treachery. **4**But, we spoke the way we did since God approved us and entrusted *us* with the good news. *We were*n't trying to please people, but God, who was approving our intentions. **5**God *is* witness: we never stooped to flattery or veiled greed, **6**or tried to get honor from you or anybody else. **7**Though as Christ's apostles, we could've expected you to support us, we were gentle among you like a nurse taking care of her kids. **8**Since you became so dear to us, we enjoyed sharing with you God's good news and our very selves. **9**You remember our labor and hardship, how we worked day and night so we wouldn't burden *you* while we presented his good news to you. **10**Along with God, you can confirm how devoutly, uprightly, blamelessly we carried ourselves among you—**11**like a father with his kids. **12**We urged you, encouraged you, and testified to you to live worthy of the One that was calling you to his kingdom and honor. **1 Th 2:1-12**

Their Openness to the Good News

[13]That's why we're constantly grateful to God. When you heard his message, you accepted it, not as a human message, but as it really is, God's message that's at work in you. [14]You followed the example of the churches of God in Christ: you suffered the same things from your countrymen that they did from the Jews—[15]who killed the Lord Jesus and the prophets, drove us out, and haven't been pleasing to God. They've been hostile to everybody [16]and tried to keep us from speaking to Gentiles about salvation, always piling up their own sins. But fury will come on them in the end.

[17]We've been away from you for a little while—in person, not in heart. [18]We've really wanted to see you, but Satan prevented it time and again. [19]Who is our hope, our joy, the crown we'll be proud of when the Lord Jesus comes? Aren't you our joy and honor? **1 Th 2:13-19**

Yearning for the Thessalonians

3:[1]When we couldn't contain our concern about you anymore, we decided to stay behind by ourselves in Athens [2]and send Timothy, our brother and fellow worker for God in the good news about Christ. He could strengthen and encourage you in your faith [3]so the troubles you were facing wouldn't disturb any of you. You know we *Christians* are destined for opposition. [4]Even when we were there, we kept telling you we'd run into trouble; and that's what happened. [5]That's why I couldn't contain *my concern for you* anymore and sent to find out about your faith. I didn't want your tempter to somehow make our labor be for nothing. **1 Th 3:1-5**

Timothy Returns with Good News

[6]Now Timothy has come back and brought us good news about your faith and love, that you have fond memories of us and want to see us like we want to see you. [7]So your faithfulness is a relief to us during our own distress. [8]Now we live if you stand firm in the Lord. [9]How can we thank God for the joy you bring us? [10]Day and night we sincerely pray to see you and to supply what your faith may lack.

[11]May God our Father and Jesus our Lord direct us back to you. [12]May the Lord increase your love for one another and everybody else like we *abound in love* for you. [13]May he make your hearts blameless in holiness in front of him when our Lord Jesus comes with his saints. Amen. **1 Th 3:6-13**

Encouragement to Please God

4:[1]Finally, we urge you by the Lord Jesus to live the way you should—like you received from us—so you improve your living even more. [2]You know what commandments we gave you from the Lord Jesus. [3]This is the will of God who sanctifies you: *that* you abstain from sexual immorality, [4]*that* each of you know how to exercise self-control in holiness and honor ([5]not *living* in lust like Gentiles, who don't know God), [6]*that* you not sin and cheat on your fellow Christian in

such a matter. The Lord avenges things—like we warned *you*. [7]He didn't call us to impurity, but to holiness. [8]So whoever rejects *that warning* isn't rejecting us, but God, who puts his Holy Spirit in us.

[9]You don't need *me* to write *to you* about brotherly love. God himself has taught you to love one another. [10]Indeed you do that to the <u>believers</u> throughout Macedonia. But we urge you to step it up [11]and make it your ambition to live quietly, mind your own business, and work with your hands; [12]so you'll be living right toward <u>outsiders</u> and won't need anything. **1 Th 4:1-12**

Hope for the Dead

[13]We want you to know about *Christians* that have died, so you won't mourn like people without hope. [14]If we believe Jesus died and resurrected, we can also believe God will bring with Jesus the ones that have died in him.

[15]We tell you from the Lord that we who are still living when he comes back won't have any advantage over the ones that have died. [16]With the shout of *an* archangel and the trumpet of God, the Lord himself will come down from heaven, and the dead in Christ will resurrect first. [17]Then we who're still living will go up with them in the clouds to meet him in the air; so we'll always be with him. [18]Console one another with that. **1 Th 4:13-18**

The Manner of Christ's Coming

5:[1]You also don't need me to write *about* when and under what circumstances *he'll return*. [2]You know full well that the Lord will come like a thief at night. [3]When people are saying, *"Peace and safety,"* destruction will come on them like a woman's birth pangs; they won't escape. [4]But <u>you</u> aren't in the dark, and that time won't overtake <u>you</u> like a thief. [5]You're children of light and day, not of darkness and night. [6]So don't sleep like other *people*; stay awake and be sober. [7]People sleep at night and get drunk at night, [8]but <u>you</u> must stay awake and sober. Put on the breastplate of faith and love, and the helmet of hope for salvation. [9]God didn't destine us to *his* fury, but to salvation through our Lord Jesus Christ. [10]He died for us; so whether we're asleep or awake, we'll live with him. [11]Comfort one another and keep building each other up like you're doing. **1 Th 5:1-11**

[12]We ask you to acknowledge the ones that labor among you, that have responsibility for you in the Lord and instruct you. [13]For their work, regard them highly with love. Be at peace with each other. [14]Warn the unruly, encourage the faint-hearted, help the weak, be patient with everyone. [15]See that nobody repays evil for evil; follow what's good for one another and for all.

[16]Rejoice always, [17]pray constantly, [18]give thanks in everything. That's God's will for you in Christ Jesus. [19]Don't quench the Spirit [20]or disregard prophecies. [21]Examine everything, hold onto what's good, [22]abstain from evil in every way, shape, and form. **1 Th 5:12-22**

Concluding Encouragement

23May the God that brings peace make you completely holy and keep your spirit, soul, and body complete and blameless for when our Lord Jesus Christ returns. **24**The One who's calling you *is* faithful and will do *what he's promised.*

25Pray for us.

26Greet all the fellow believers with a holy kiss.

27By the Lord, I charge you to read *this* letter to the whole church.

28The grace of our Lord Jesus Christ *be* with you[pl]. **1 Th 5:23-28**

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